

ADVANCEDDOCUMENTWORKFLOW

Standard Operating Procedure Library

20 SOPs for Documenting How Your Business Actually Runs

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1. How To Use This SOP Library

This library contains 20 Standard Operating Procedures covering the recurring tasks that keep a small or growing business running consistently. The first five are fully written, ready-to-deploy SOPs you can hand to a new hire today. The remaining fifteen are blank templates that follow the exact same structure, so your team can document your own processes in a format that stays consistent across every department.

An SOP is only useful if someone who has never done the task before can follow it and get the same result as your most experienced employee. Write every step as a specific, observable action, not a general instruction: 'Verify the invoice total matches the purchase order' is usable; 'process the invoice correctly' is not.

The SOP Template Structure

Every SOP in this library — written or blank — follows the same seven-part structure, so anyone on your team can find what they need without hunting through inconsistent formats:

- Title — a short, specific name that describes exactly what the procedure covers.
- Purpose — one to two sentences explaining why this procedure exists.
- Scope — what this SOP applies to, and what it does not cover.
- Responsible Parties — the roles accountable for each part of the process.
- Procedure Steps — a numbered, sequential list a new hire could follow unassisted.
- References — related policies, forms, systems, or other SOPs this one depends on.
- Revision History — a log of when the SOP was created and updated, and what changed.

Rolling Out a New SOP

- Assign one owner per SOP who is accountable for keeping it current.
- Review every SOP at least once per year, or immediately after a process changes.
- Store the finished library somewhere every employee can access.

SOP 1: Employee Onboarding Process

Purpose

To ensure every new hire completes a consistent, documented onboarding experience from offer acceptance through their 90-day review, reducing ramp-up time and early turnover.

Scope

Applies to all full-time, part-time, and contract employees onboarded directly by the company. Excludes temporary staffing agency placements.

Responsible Parties

- HR Coordinator — owns the onboarding checklist and timeline
- Hiring Manager — owns role-specific training and check-ins
- IT Administrator — owns equipment and account provisioning
- Payroll Specialist — owns payroll and benefits setup

Procedure Steps

1. Send the pre-boarding packet (offer letter, benefits summary, I-9/W-4 forms) within 24 hours of verbal offer acceptance.
2. Hiring Manager submits an IT provisioning ticket at least 5 business days before the start date.
3. HR conducts a 90-minute Day 1 orientation covering policies, benefits enrollment, and safety procedures.
4. Hiring Manager assigns the department training checklist and pairs the new hire with an onboarding buddy.
5. HR schedules a documented 30-day check-in to review progress and confirm benefits enrollment is complete.
6. Hiring Manager holds a 60-day performance touchpoint, documenting early concerns or training needs.
7. Hiring Manager and HR jointly complete the 90-day review; employee moves to standard employment status.

References

- Employee Handbook
- IT Provisioning Policy
- Benefits Enrollment Guide

Revision History

- v1.0 — Jan 2025 — Initial release
- v1.1 — Jun 2025 — Added 60-day performance touchpoint step

SOP 2: Customer Complaint Handling

Purpose

To standardize how customer complaints are logged, triaged, resolved, and escalated, preserving customer trust while producing consistent data for continuous improvement.

Scope

Applies to all inbound complaints received by the Customer Support team through phone, email, live chat, or social media. Does not cover formal legal disputes, which route directly to Legal.

Responsible Parties

- Support Agent — first responder and owner of routine complaints
- Support Team Lead — approves exceptions and handles escalations
- Customer Success Manager — reviews recurring complaint trends

Procedure Steps

1. Log the complaint verbatim in the CRM within 1 business hour of receipt, capturing channel, order/product reference, and stated severity.
2. Send an acknowledgment to the customer within 4 business hours confirming the complaint was received and the expected timeline.
3. Classify the complaint as Low, Medium, or High severity using the Severity Matrix; High severity automatically escalates to the Team Lead.
4. Investigate the root cause by reviewing order history, account notes, and relevant product or shipping logs before responding.
5. Propose a resolution aligned with the Refund & Replacement Policy; obtain Team Lead approval for any exception to standard policy.
6. Follow up with the customer within 48 hours of resolution to confirm satisfaction with the outcome.
7. Close the ticket with a root-cause tag; Team Lead reviews the weekly trend report to flag recurring issues for process improvement.

References

- Refund & Replacement Policy
- Complaint Severity Matrix
- CRM Field Guide

Revision History

- v1.0 — Feb 2025 — Initial release
- v1.1 — May 2025 — Added automatic High-severity escalation

SOP 3: Invoice Processing & Approval

Purpose

To ensure vendor invoices are verified, coded, approved, and paid accurately and on schedule, protecting vendor relationships and avoiding late fees or duplicate payments.

Scope

Applies to all vendor invoices received by Accounts Payable. Does not apply to recurring payroll disbursements, which follow the Payroll Processing SOP.

Responsible Parties

- AP Clerk — logs, matches, and codes each invoice
- Department Budget Owner — approves invoices charged to their budget
- Controller — approves invoices above the dual-approval threshold

Procedure Steps

1. Log the invoice into the accounting system within 1 business day of receipt, recording vendor, amount, and due date.
2. Perform a 3-way match against the purchase order and the delivery or receiving confirmation before proceeding.
3. Code the invoice to the correct general ledger account and cost center per the Chart of Accounts.
4. Route invoices under \$2,500 to the Budget Owner for approval; route invoices of \$2,500 or more to both the Budget Owner and the Controller.
5. Contact the vendor directly to resolve any pricing or quantity discrepancies before scheduling payment.
6. Schedule payment according to the vendor's stated terms, prioritizing any available early-payment discount.
7. Archive the approved invoice packet with proof of payment for the audit retention period defined in company policy.

References

- Chart of Accounts
- Purchasing Policy
- Vendor Payment Terms Log

Revision History

- v1.0 — Mar 2025 — Initial release
- v1.1 — Jul 2025 — Added dual-approval threshold for invoices \$2,500+

SOP 4: IT Equipment Request

Purpose

To define a consistent process for requesting, approving, and issuing IT equipment, controlling costs while keeping the company's asset inventory accurate.

Scope

Applies to all requests for computers, monitors, peripherals, and mobile devices submitted by employees or department managers.

Responsible Parties

- Requesting Employee or Manager — initiates the request
- Department Manager — approves budget and business justification
- IT Asset Coordinator — sources, configures, and issues equipment

Procedure Steps

1. Submit an equipment request through the IT ticketing system, specifying the equipment type and business justification.
2. Department Manager approves or denies the request within 2 business days based on budget and need.
3. IT Asset Coordinator checks refurbished inventory before approving the purchase of new equipment.
4. IT Asset Coordinator either allocates existing inventory or places a purchase order for new equipment.
5. IT Asset Coordinator images the device with standard software, registers the asset tag, and issues it to the employee.
6. Employee signs an equipment acknowledgment form; IT updates the asset management system with the new assignment.

References

- IT Asset Management Policy
- Approved Hardware Catalog

Revision History

- v1.0 — Apr 2025 — Initial release

SOP 5: Social Media Posting Protocol

Purpose

To ensure all social media content is on-brand, factually accurate, and properly approved before publishing, minimizing reputational and legal risk.

Scope

Applies to all posts published on official company social media accounts across every platform. Does not cover personal employee social media use.

Responsible Parties

- Social Media Coordinator — drafts and schedules content
- Marketing Manager — reviews for brand voice and accuracy
- Legal Reviewer — reviews sensitive claims or promotions as needed

Procedure Steps

1. Draft the caption, visuals, and hashtags from the monthly editorial calendar.
2. Marketing Manager reviews the draft for brand voice, factual accuracy, and image rights compliance.
3. Route any post referencing pricing, product claims, or promotions to Legal for review before scheduling.
4. Schedule the approved post using the company's social media management tool.
5. Monitor comments and direct messages within 2 hours of publishing to catch and route any urgent responses.
6. Log reach, engagement rate, and click-through data in the monthly content performance report.

References

- Brand Style Guide
- Social Media Crisis Response Plan

Revision History

- v1.0 — May 2025 — Initial release

7. SOPs 6-20 — Blank Templates

The remaining fifteen SOPs follow the same structure as SOPs 1-5. Use each template below to document your own version of these common business processes.

SOP 6: Inventory Count (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 7: Vendor Evaluation (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 8: Meeting Scheduling (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 9: Document Archiving (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 10: Travel Request (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 11: Expense Reporting (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 12: Performance Review (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 13: Data Backup (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 14: Security Incident Response (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 15: Office Supply Ordering (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 16: Client Onboarding (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 17: Newsletter Publishing (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 18: Website Update (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 19: Event Planning (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

SOP 20: Annual Report Preparation (Template)

Title

Purpose

Scope

Responsible Parties

Procedure Steps

References

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